

IMO FAL 50 Meeting Summary

13 April 2026



The 50th meeting of the Facilitation Committee (FAL 50) was held from 23 to 27 March 2026 at the IMO headquarters in London, supplemented by hybrid (online) arrangements.

LISCR participated in the following groups in addition to the plenary:

Group and location	Subject (Agenda)
WG 1	Facilitation Instruments
WG 2	Electronic Business
WG 3	Other Facilitation Subjects

Decisions of other IMO bodies

Outcome of 36th extraordinary session of the IMO Council regarding the situation in the Arabian Sea, Sea of Oman and the Gulf Region, particularly in and around the Strait of Hormuz

FAL 50 noted the outcome of C/ES.36, during which delegations expressed concern over the impact of the ongoing conflict on international shipping, seafarers, freedom of navigation and global supply chains, and emphasized the need for de-escalation and diplomatic resolution. Diverging views were expressed, with some delegations cautioning against the politicization of IMO's work and others calling for a focus on the Organization's technical mandate and practical measures to safeguard maritime safety and security. FAL 50 acknowledged the Council's Declaration, noted general support for the proposal, and requested the Secretary-General to continue engagement with relevant parties, provide updates on the situation and its impact on shipping and seafarers, and report to a future session, while agreeing to consider further submissions under an existing agenda item.

FAL Convention

FAL 50 finalized and adopted draft amendments to the FAL Convention on alignment with the International Health Regulations (2005), including clarification of the Maritime Ship Declaration of Health as the primary health document, inclusion of Ship Sanitation Certificates, and related adjustments to provisions and forms (including IMO FAL Form 1), together with an update to Recommended Practice 6.24 on crew welfare, vaccinations and medical access during public health emergencies. The amendments will enter into force on 1 January 2028.

Advance Passenger Information (API) and Booking and Reservation Information (BRI)

FAL 50 approved draft amendments to the FAL Convention on API and BRI for adoption by FAL 51 scheduled for 2027.

Introduction of Advance Passenger and Crew Information (API)

FAL 50 agreed to retain a non-mandatory approach to API, leaving implementation to the discretion of Contracting Governments, while introducing a new draft Standard requiring public authorities to establish the necessary systems before mandating data transmission. It also supported aligning the FAL Convention API data fields with the IMO Compendium, while noting concerns about the scope and operational burden of the dataset, and requested EGDH to consider adding certain missing data elements to ensure consistency with existing FAL declarations.

Introduction of Booking and Reservation Information (BRI)

FAL 50 agreed on a draft Recommended Practice for the collection of BRI data, under which public authorities may request such information only after establishing the necessary capability, and only to the extent that the data are already collected by shipowners in the normal course of business.

Cybersecurity for Maritime Single Window (MSW)

FAL 50 considered and finalized draft amendments to the FAL Convention to introduce mandatory cybersecurity measures for MSWs, maintaining a binding requirement while allowing flexibility for implementation in accordance with national legislation and ensuring technology neutrality. The draft amendments establish a new obligation for Contracting Governments to implement cybersecurity measures to safeguard MSW systems, and were prepared together with a draft resolution for adoption at FAL 51. It was also recognized that implementation would have capacity-building implications, and that the Technical Cooperation Committee may be invited to support Member States through the Integrated Technical Cooperation Programme (ITCP).

Maritime Single Window

FAL 50 considered proposed SMART indicators for monitoring MSW implementation and noted concerns that they rely on GISIS reporting rather than reflecting actual operational systems or legal readiness, and that purely quantitative indicators may not capture effective implementation. FAL 50 agreed to use the indicators as an initial basis, to be refined over time with additional qualitative inputs such as surveys, and encouraged Member States to improve reporting through GISIS.

IMO Compendium on Facilitation and Electronic Business, including additional e-business solutions

The IMO Compendium is the standard data set required for ship-port data exchange.

At FAL 43 (held in 2019), it was agreed that the maintenance of the Compendium would be transferred from the World Customs Organization (WCO) to the IMO. A partnership agreement exists between IMO, WCO, the United Nations Economic Commission for Europe (UNECE), and the International Organization for Standardization (ISO) to support this effort.

Updates on the IMO Compendium

The IMO Compendium is a harmonized framework for maritime datasets. The new version includes sensitive information such as personal identity data and crew medical information. For this reason, Liberia called for a cautious approach to data handling.

IMO Strategy on Maritime Digitalization

The FAL Committee has been working on the comprehensive strategy on Maritime Digitalization.

IMO Strategy on Maritime Digitalization

FAL 50 developed a draft IMO Strategy on Maritime Digitalization as a high-level, principle-based framework aimed at promoting a harmonized and interoperable global maritime digital ecosystem, while remaining within IMO's mandate and aligned with international standards. The Strategy sets out a vision of secure and seamless data exchange, supported by guiding principles including interoperability, data governance, cybersecurity and human-centred design, explicitly emphasizing user needs and reduction of administrative burden for seafarers and operators, alongside objectives to enhance efficiency, safety, environmental performance and data-driven decision-making. The scope covers IMO processes, the maritime industry, data standards, ship-shore communication, digital identity and cybersecurity, with a focus on interoperability between platforms rather than prescribing specific systems.

FAL 50 agreed to forward the draft Strategy to MSC, MEPC and LEG for review and approval, with a view to finalization at FAL 51 and adoption by the Assembly in 2027, supported by an action plan and coordinated cross-Committee input.

Action plan

FAL 50 agreed to commence development of an action plan to support the IMO Strategy on Maritime Digitalization, to be prepared by a re-established correspondence group for consideration at FAL 51. The action plan will identify gaps and potential new work streams, with input from other IMO Committees; however, any new work identified will still require formal new output proposals and approval through established IMO procedures.

The work will continue by the correspondence group (CG), which will also consider possible integration of IMO Strategy on Maritime Digitalization into the IMO's Strategy Direction in the IMO's Strategic Plan.

Maritime Autonomous Surface Ships (MASS)

FAL 50 revised and agreed an updated roadmap for addressing MASS within the FAL Convention framework, establishing a phased approach aligned with the development of the MASS Code. In the near term, FAL 51 is to assess the adopted non-mandatory MASS Code and consider any necessary interpretations or amendments to the FAL Convention, while later stages foresee further review following the development of a mandatory MASS Code and eventual adoption of

corresponding FAL amendments. The work remains contingent on progress in MSC and the availability of concrete proposals, and FAL 50 noted that establishing a dedicated working group at FAL 51 will depend on such progress and submissions.

Stowaways

Guidelines on Stowaway cases

FAL 50 finalized revised guidelines and an associated resolution on the prevention of access by stowaways and the allocation of responsibilities for resolving stowaway cases, incorporating targeted amendments and editorial updates to align with the latest FAL Convention provisions. Key changes included clarifying the role of public authorities, restructuring provisions to elevate core principles (including disembarkation) within the “Basic Principles” section, and reinforcing cooperation among shipowners, masters, port authorities and States to prevent incidents and ensure timely, humane resolution and repatriation of stowaways, while maintaining consistency with existing international frameworks.

Stowaways reporting

FAL 50 noted the following trend of stowaway cases:

Year	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Number of incidents	61	28	55	63	49	55	54	50	64	62	45	26
Number of stowaways	120	80	163	157	182	138	55	96	131	161	92	37

FAL 50 urged Member States and international organizations to provide timely and accurate information on stowaway cases to the Organization, making use of the GISIS module in accordance with Standard 4.7.1 of the FAL Convention.

Unsafe mixed migration by sea

Guidelines concerning the recovery of deceased persons and death after recovery

FAL 50 recalled earlier discussions on the draft MSC-FAL circular concerning the recovery of deceased persons and death after recovery, including differing views at FAL 49 regarding competence and implications for SAR responsibilities, and noted that MSC 110 had approved the circular. FAL 50 concurred with MSC 110 and approved MSC-FAL.1/Circ.4 on *Guidelines concerning the recovery of deceased persons and death after recovery*.

Work programme

The following were agreed for inclusion:

- **Guidelines on port nautical information:** FAL 50 agreed to include in the 2026-2027 biennial agenda of the FAL Committee and the provisional agenda for FAL 51 an output on "Development of guidelines on port nautical information", with a target completion year of 2028, and to invite the Maritime Safety Committee to participate as an associated organ in the development of the guidelines, with the possible participation of NCSR.
- **Amendments to the FAL Convention to align it with the 2024 amendments to the International Health Regulations (2005):** FAL 50 agreed to include in the 2026-2027 biennial agenda with a target completion year of 2027.
- **Non-mandatory maritime cyber code:** FAL 50 agreed to:
 - include in the 2026-2027 biennial agenda of the FAL Committee and the provisional agenda for FAL 51, the output "Develop a non-mandatory maritime cyber code", with a target completion year of 2028;
 - invite the Maritime Safety Committee to participate as an associated organ in the development of this code;
 - approve the road map and invite MSC for concurrent approval; and
 - approve the formation of an Interessional Correspondence Group to Develop the Maritime Cyber Code, with the understanding that this correspondence group could start its work following C 137 consideration and endorsement of this new output.

Any other business

Proposal for a joint ICAO/ILO/IMO/WHO working group on key workers

FAL 50 recalled the proposal made at FAL 49 to establish a joint ICAO/ILO/IMO/WHO working group on the protection of key workers during public health emergencies, and noted the outcome of inter-agency consultations, which highlighted legal and practical complexities. FAL 50 agreed not to establish such a working group and instead requested continued cooperation among the secretariats, with updates to be provided as appropriate.

Contact Committee on API and BRI/PNR

FAL 50 recalled that FAL 49 had recommended IMO participation as a partner in the WCO-led Contact Committee on API and BRI/PNR, and noted that Council 134 had approved this membership together with revised terms of reference and procedures for participation. FAL 50 further noted the ongoing work of the Contact Committee, including the reopening of its terms of reference for amendment and upcoming meetings, and invited interested experts to participate through the Secretariat.

Business continuity for cross-border MSW data exchange

FAL 50 noted information from China and Singapore on a fully operational joint e-certificate data exchange system between their MSWs, including the development of a Business Continuity Procedure following successful testing to ensure resilience in case of disruption, and recognized its potential as a model for other Member States. FAL 50 also noted concerns raised by IBLA regarding the implementation of safety requirements for berthing personnel and urged Member States to ensure effective application of the relevant IMO resolution.

Further information

For further information please contact: imo@lisscr.com

Annex

List of finalized instruments

- Amendments to the FAL Convention on alignment with the International Health Regulations (2005)
- Revised guidelines and an associated resolution on the prevention of access by stowaways and the allocation of responsibilities for resolving stowaway cases
- MSC-FAL.1/Circ.4 on Guidelines concerning the recovery of deceased persons and death after recovery
- Amendments to FAL.8/Circ.1/Rev.1 on the Organization and method of work of the Facilitation Committee